together only by economic largesse and grim appreciation that the costs of war are immense. Where compromise cannot be found, Myanmar's people suffer through long-running jousts, which can sometimes escalate into full-blown battles, forcing thousands from their homes. During the past half-decade — even as life in Myanmar improved for tens of millions of people — difficult conditions have remained in parts of the Shan, Kachin and Rakhine States. In certain areas, ethnic armed forces have battled hard against the central government, unwilling to concede ground to what they consider occupying forces.

In the past, there was in fact no clear distinction between Myanmar's armed forces, often known by their Burmese name, the Tatmadaw, and the central government. Under the State Peace and Development Council (SPDC) that ruled until 2011, Myanmar's military high command and executive leadership were one-and-the-same (see Seekins 1999; Rogers 2009; Farrelly 2013). In practice, this system gave army officers, whatever their rank, dual responsibilities as both administrators and war-fighters. For instance, the head of Myanmar's Northern Command, usually a major general based in the Kachin State capital, Myitkyina, also served as the chairman of the Kachin State Peace and Development Council. This parallel structure disciplined civilian bureaucrats to the expectations of their military superiors. The SPDC mandated strict limits on all public spheres, and there was relatively severe scrutiny of information flows, publications and artistic expression (Brooten 2006; Carlson 2016; also Brooten 2013). The education system and the media were strangled so that only officially endorsed perspectives were circulated openly (Han Tin 2008, pp. 121–123). Dissenters were rounded up and subjected to long periods of incarceration (see Cheesman 2015). Many decided that survival under the military regime was impossible and fled abroad for a better chance at a livelihood and happiness. Thailand ended up absorbing millions of Myanmar exiles and migrants; thousands more ventured to Malaysia, Singapore, India and China (Farrelly 2012a; Meyer et al 2015). Significant numbers were also resettled in the western democracies that, with varying degrees of assertiveness, kept up pressure on the military regime.

What is remarkable is just how much has changed since the formal end of the SPDC era in 2011. The first step was the transition to a semi-civilian regime, where former senior military officers, including top brass from the SPDC, managed the new constitutional government (Egreteau 2014). President Thein Sein, who had been the fourth ranking officer in the SPDC,